approached with the request that a budgetary sanction be made for the purchase of one tripper truck. The request was denied on grounds of maintenance problems that the prison authorities may have to face in the future. Their advice, therefore, was to engage private trucks for the job, which were to be paid for from the prison budget. With no immediate options, this move was resorted to. From actuals it was estimated that it would deplete the prison budget by an annual amount of Rs 21 lakh. It was at this moment that K. C. Shroff, managing director of Excel Industries (Bombay), introduced by Dr S. C. Vatts, came to Tihar's rescue. He had read about the ongoing revolutionary reforms taking place in Tihar and offered his company's expertise in converting organic garbage into odourless, rich manure. The offer was grabbed and within days the project was launched. Excel provided the chemicals and knowhow and the inmates volunteered to run the project. This odourless, highly nutrient biofertilizer was marketed by the prison to local nurseries for kitchen garden purposes. Thus, the 3000 kg (per day) of organic prison garbage would, on projections made on actuals, fetch the prisoners' welfare fund a sum of about Rs 21 lakh per annum. As a result, about Rs 11 lakh of expenditure would have been saved annually and, on top of that, a profit of about Rs 10 lakh would have accrued: in effect Rs 21 lakh in hand by the year-end.

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* Also known as 'the bandit queen', she became a Member of Parliament in 1996. She was shot dead on 25 July 2001 in New Delhi.